

FOR SCHOOL LEADERS

The **deepfake** incident: a school's day-one response plan

From My PR Partner. Five steps, plus the parent letter you hope you never send.

AI-generated image abuse has arrived in Australian schools. The eSafety Commissioner has published guidance for schools because incidents are no longer rare, and schools that respond well have one thing in common: they decided what they would do before it happened. This plan covers the first day. The parent letter template on the next page covers the hardest hour of it.

A note before you need this: creating or sharing sexually explicit material of a person under 18, including AI-generated material, is a crime. Day one is not only a communications event. It is a child safety and legal event, and your communications must follow that order of priority.

1 Protect the students involved first

Before any communication goes anywhere: make sure affected students are safe and supported. Engage your wellbeing team, contact the families of affected students personally (phone, not email), and put support in place the same day. Every later message will be judged against whether you did this first. Do not confront or publicly identify any student alleged to be responsible; that is a matter for the process, not the public.

2 Report and preserve, do not investigate alone

Report material involving minors to police and follow their direction before communicating details. Report the material to the platform and to the eSafety Commissioner (esafety.gov.au), which has legal powers to compel removal. Preserve evidence (URLs, usernames, timestamps) without downloading or further distributing the material itself. Notify your sector authority or system office as your obligations require.

3 Convene your response team and agree one voice

Principal, deputy, wellbeing lead, and whoever handles media and parent communication. Agree who speaks (usually the principal, and only the principal), what is known versus assumed, and the update rhythm. Prepare for the story to leave your community: parents talk, screenshots move, and journalists monitor parent Facebook groups.

4 Communicate early, in the right order

Affected families first, personally. Staff second, so they hear it from you and know what to say and not say. The parent community third, using the letter on the next page. Media last, and only with a short, prepared statement. The biggest mistake schools make is waiting until every fact is known; by then the Facebook group has written the story for you. You are not announcing conclusions, you are demonstrating that the school is acting.

5 Lead the emotion before the information

Parents reading your letter are frightened, and frightened people cannot hear facts: you cannot beat emotion with logic. Validate what families are feeling before you explain what the school is doing, and never follow that validation with the word "but". Then commit to updates and keep every commitment. The letter template overleaf is built exactly this way.

TEMPLATE

The parent letter, ready before you need it

Adapt the **[gold placeholders]** to your school and the facts you have confirmed. Send it from the principal personally, the same day the school community becomes aware. Keep it factual, calm and free of legal hedging: parents forgive a school that acts and speaks like humans, and they do not forgive silence. Check wording against police advice before sending.

Dear parents and carers,

I am writing to tell you about a serious matter, because you should hear it from me and not from social media.

The school has become aware that digitally altered images, sometimes called deepfakes, appearing to depict **[a student / students]** of our school have been created and shared online. We understand how distressing this is. As a parent, I would be angry and worried too, and many of you will be feeling exactly that today. Those feelings are entirely understandable, and I want you to know the school shares them.

Here is what we have done since becoming aware: we have contacted and are personally supporting the affected families; we have reported the matter to **[the police / the eSafety Commissioner]** and are following their direction; we have requested the removal of the material; and our wellbeing team is available to any student who needs support, whether directly involved or not.

Because this matter involves young people and an active **[police / eSafety]** process, there are details I am not able to share, and I ask for your understanding on that. What I can promise is this: I will update you by **[day / date]**, and sooner if there is something you need to know. If you have information about this matter, or if your child is affected in any way, please contact **[name and direct contact]** rather than discussing it on social media, where sharing or commenting can spread the material further and cause more harm to the young people involved.

Please also take this as a moment to talk with your child about AI image tools. The eSafety Commissioner has excellent guidance for families at esafety.gov.au. Our school community is strongest when we face hard things together, openly and with care for every child involved. Thank you for your support and your trust.

[Name]

[Principal, School Name]

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